THE FREE 2026 PLAYBOOK FOR SANTA CLARITA HOME BUYERS

The Buyer's Edge

5 moves that protect your money in the 2026 Santa Clarita market, from a 28-year agent who does not represent buyers and has no reason to rush you.

CONNOR MacIVOR · CONNOR WITH HONOR

READ THIS BEFORE YOU TOUR A SINGLE HOUSE

The market shifted. Most buyers are playing by 2022 rules.

Santa Clarita is sitting at about 730 active listings as I write this, up from roughly 500 back in January. That is not a small move. More homes on the market means more room, more leverage, and more time to think than buyers have had in years. The frenzy is over. The trap is that most people are still bracing for a bidding war that is not happening anymore.

Here is who I am, and why this report does not read like everyone else's. I am a sellers-only agent. I do not represent buyers, which means I have nothing to sell you and no commission riding on talking you into a house this weekend. When I do connect you with a buyer's agent, it is someone I trust, and I am genuinely on your side of the table. So I can tell you the truth, even the parts that cost an agent a fast paycheck.

These are the 5 moves that protect your money this year. Each one kills a specific trap that is quietly costing buyers thousands. Read it, use it, and if you want the live numbers for your exact zip code, the last page tells you how to get them in about ten seconds.

Let's protect your money. — Connor

THE FIVE MOVES

Each one kills a trap that is costing buyers money right now.

01 Stop Buying the Rate. Buy the Payment and the Plan.

THE TRAP

Buyers freeze because the news screams that rates are high. Historically they are not, and the 1970s comparison everyone reaches for ignores that homes and incomes back then were a fraction of today. People wait for a magic rate and watch prices climb past them while they sit.

THE MOVE

Decide on a monthly payment you can carry without stress, then work backward to a price with your lender. You marry the house and you date the rate. If rates fall later, you refinance. If they do not, you still own the home while renters keep paying someone else's mortgage. The rate is one number. Your income, your debt load, and your timeline are the numbers that actually decide whether now is your time.

> **DO THIS NOW** Write down the monthly payment that lets you sleep. That number, not the headline rate, is your real budget.

02 Shop the Lender Like You Shop the House.

THE TRAP

Most buyers take the first lender a friend named, get one quote, and never compare. Loan costs hide under a dozen different names, and an extra half percent or a pile of junk fees can cost you tens of thousands over the life of the loan.

THE MOVE

Interview at least two lenders, and put a mortgage broker in the mix, not just a big bank. A bank offers that one bank's products and rules. A broker can shop many lenders, sometimes 50, and find the one that fits your credit profile and the specific property. Make every one of them hand you a written net sheet, and ask straight out how they get paid. The property matters too, because an FHA or VA loan can be blocked on certain homes where a more flexible product sails through.

> **DO THIS NOW** Get two real pre-approvals and lay the net sheets side by side. Same loan amount, compare the all-in cost line by line.

03 Use the Leverage You Did Not Have a Year Ago.

THE TRAP

Buyers still walk in apologizing, waiving everything, and overpaying out of a fear that there are ten offers behind them. In a rising-inventory market that fear is usually wrong, and it is expensive.

THE MOVE

Read the market through days on market. When homes are sitting longer and inventory is climbing, you have room to negotiate the things that actually save money: a price reduction, closing-cost credits, and especially a seller-paid rate buydown that can drop your payment for the first years you own the home. You can ask for repairs and keep your inspection contingency instead of stripping every protection to look aggressive. Aggressive does not win in this market. Informed does.

> **DO THIS NOW** Before you offer, have your agent pull the days on market for that home and that neighborhood. Slow movers are where your leverage lives.

04 Value the Home on Real Comps, Not a Portal Guess.

THE TRAP

The estimate on the big syndication sites is not built to value your home. It is built to capture your contact information and sell it to an agent. Buyers anchor to that number, high or low, and either overpay or lose a good house chasing a fantasy price.

THE MOVE

Demand real comparable sales. You want three to five homes that are genuine model matches, in the same tract, the same builder community, as close to the same year built as possible, that closed in the last 90 to 180 days. Same-zip, same-model, recently closed comps end the argument about what a home is worth. A comp from another city or a different valley does not belong anywhere near your offer. When you can see the real numbers, you stop guessing and start negotiating from facts.

> **DO THIS NOW** For any home you love, ask for the three closest closed comps in that same tract from the last 90 days. If your agent cannot produce them, that is your answer.

05 Take the Emotion Out. It Is a Money Decision.

THE TRAP

You will fall in love. You will hang the mental curtains before you have even read the disclosures. That is exactly when buyers overpay, skip protections, and ignore the quiet voice that says slow down. Sellers feel it too, and two emotional sides turn a clean deal into a war.

THE MOVE

Treat the purchase as what it is, a financial decision that either makes sense or puts you in a better life, and run it on data and documents instead of feelings. Keep your contingencies, your inspection, your appraisal, your loan, because those are the exits that protect your deposit. Put every agreement in writing, never on a handshake, and use an extension-of-time addendum when you genuinely need more room to decide. The right agent will tell you when to walk, even when it costs them, and that one sentence is worth more than any house tour.

DO THIS NOW Pick your walk-away number and your three must-haves before you tour. Write them down so the emotion of the moment cannot quietly move them.

THE BONUS MOVE MOST AGENTS SKIP

Line up your buyer's agent before you fall for a house, not after.

The biggest unforced error I see is buyers touring homes for weeks with no agent in their corner, then scrambling to find one the day they want to write an offer. That is exactly backward. The agent is the person who pulls your comps, spots the bad disclosure, holds your contingencies, and negotiates the buydown. You want them locked in before the emotion hits, not during it.

And if you have to sell to buy, the sequencing is its own skill. Done wrong, you end up owning two homes or none. Done right, the sale funds the purchase with a rent-back or a contingency that protects you. That is the one place my world and yours overlap, because selling is exactly what I do, every day, in this valley.

Want the live numbers for your zip code?

This report gives you the moves. The numbers change every week. Tell me where you are looking and I will send you the current days on market, the real closed comps, and an introduction to a buyer's agent I personally trust. I am sellers-only, so I am not trying to be your agent. I am trying to make sure you do not get worked over by someone who is.

Your move: Reply **BUYER** to the message that sent you this report. Tell me the area or zip you are watching, and I will send your live SCV numbers and the right introduction. No pressure, no spam, just straight answers.

Connor MacIvor is a sellers-only real estate agent with 28 years in the Santa Clarita Valley, and breaks down real estate and the AI economy daily on the Connor with Honor show. This report is free. Share it with anyone you know who is thinking about buying in SCV this year.